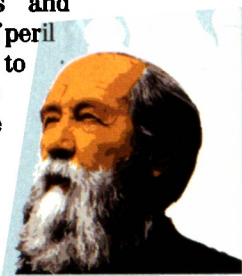


LOCOMOTIF S. PRASANNARAJAN

The Lie Detector

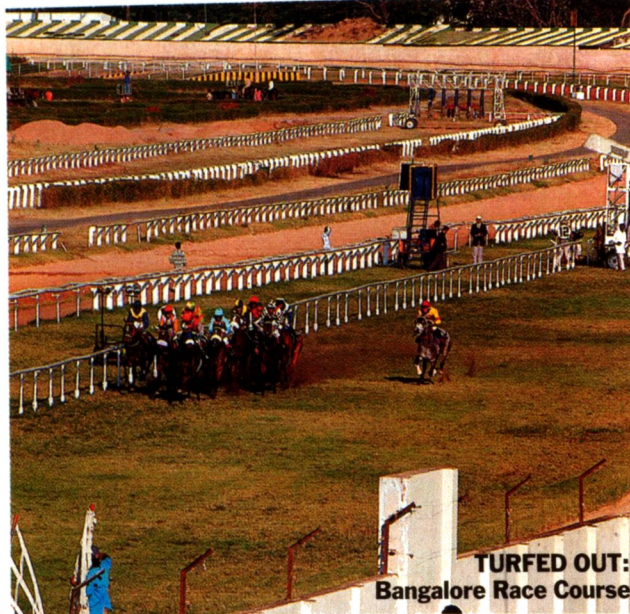


Censorship is the mother of metaphor, wrote Jorge Luis Borges. And that is why the art of the novel owes a great deal to the dehumanising lie of communism. Alexander Solzhenitsyn (1918-2008), a novelist born out of the dark recesses of Stalinist Russia, not only outlived the lie that denied him his words but, as the author of *The Gulag Archipelago* and *One Day in the Life of Ivan Denisovitch*, became the most widely read chronicler of the Evil that banished questions and confiscated conscience. As the poet Anna Akhmatova wrote about her friend Osip Mandelstam, *But in the room of the banished poet/Fear and the Muse stand watch by turn,/and the night falls/without the hope of dawn*. Solzhenitsyn, victim, survivor and prophet, refused to abandon hope, even though he would come to hate the dawn. For, at a time when the Soviet monolith looked imperishable to its architects and acolytes, he warned: "The hour of peril will come, and you will appeal to your people once more, not to world communism." From the idyllic remoteness of Vermont, US, the world's most famous exile would watch the fall of the Soviet empire, the final unraveling of the Lie.



SAURABH SINGH

The new Russia let him down, and he raged against that soulless alternative like an angry Slavic Jehovah. In *Rebuilding Russia* (1992), a passionate polemic that was a manifesto for the homeland, he unveiled his own Edenic version of the future. A Slavic future that would restore the supremacy of soul. He found no virtue in constitutional democracy, and governance in his Russia would "entail an admixture of the aristocratic or even monarchical modes." His alternative would be sustained by a parliament of "national conscience" and the moral commandments of the lofty few. This vision warmed only the hearts of the mystic militants from the Church, and the children of glasnost, to their horror, began to see traces of a Slavic Ayatollah in the great idol of resistance. When he returned to Russia in 1994, one of the most poignant homecomings in history, there was nothing there to cheer him up. On Sunday, the Russia to which he bid his final farewell was closer to the homeland of his mind: there is a stronger sense of national pride in the Putin country. We are indebted to Solzhenitsyn because he lived not only to tell the tale of the Great Terror but to meditate on the idea of Russia. As a writer who saw himself as Tolstoyan in his "narrative form" and Dostoevskian in his "spiritual interpretation of history", Solzhenitsyn was every bit Russian: epic and flawed.



New Course for Horses

BANGALORE Bangalore Race Course, an 85-acre prime landmark of the city and a familiar haunt for race horse owners like liquor baron Vijay Mallya and industrialist M.A.M. Ramaswamy, is now finally being turfed out. Karnataka Chief Minister B.S. Yeddyurappa announced this in the Assembly, saying that the government will not extend the race course's lease beyond December 2009. However, Congress legislator Roshan Baig wants it to be maintained as a lung space since the city is being choked with seven million people and almost three million vehicles. PWD Minister C.M. Udasi, who has already hinted that the race course will be shunted out to the outskirts, says the Government wants to build underground parking lots there to ease parking and traffic woes.

Various state Governments over the past 20 years have mulled over shifting the race course,

which was founded by four Britishers in the early part of the century on land leased by the Maharaja of Mysore. In the early 1980s, the then chief minister Ramakrishna Hegde wanted it to be relocated to the vicinity of the Jakkur flying school. However, successive governments dithered, with H.D. Kumaraswamy even dropping the idea.

Some BJP leaders like Ramachandra Gowda insist that all forms of gambling should be banned. A high-level committee comprising legal experts has also been scrutinising various judgments of the Supreme Court and the high courts relating to horse racing and betting. Recently, a court classified horse racing as a sport while setting aside the ban on it in Tamil Nadu. Since the idea of shifting the race course has come from the horse's mouth itself this time, Hegde's long pending blueprint may just see the light of day.

by Stephen David